

Building a Cross-Platform Movie Discovery App with React Native: A Beginner Developer's Evaluation and Usability Study

Sujan Tiwari

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Abstract

Author
Sujan Tiwari

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1 Introduction

Many companies and developers need to make mobile apps for both Android and iOS. Building two separate native apps takes more time, more skills and more maintenance. Cross-platform frameworks such as React Native let developers build one app that works on both platforms (Biørn-Hansen, Grønli & Ghinea 2018).

For a beginner, it is not clear how easy React Native is to learn, how much extra work each platform still needs, and whether the finished app is easy for real people to use. I started learning React Native from scratch in spring 2026, so I can study this question from my own experience.

The application in this thesis is a movie discovery app. Movies and series are spread across many streaming services, such as Netflix, Disney+, HBO Max, Prime Video, Apple TV and Viaplay. People often have to open several apps to find out where they can watch something. Having too many choices can also make it harder to decide (Iyengar & Lepper 2000).

This is a product-based thesis. The product is a working first version (MVP) of a movie discovery app for Android and iOS. I use the project to evaluate React Native from a beginner's point of view and test the app with real users.

I used the AI assistant Claude to help edit the document to Haaga Helia specification and to simplify the language.

2 Significance of the Product-based Thesis

The thesis has no client company. It is useful for these groups:

- **Beginner developers and small teams** who are choosing between React Native and native development. This documented experience gives them practical information about learning React Native and building for two platforms.
- **Young adults who use streaming services.** The app shows quickly where a movie can be watched in their country and suggests movies from the services they already have.
- **Career as a developer.** I learn React Native, TypeScript, APIs and user testing and the app becomes part of my portfolio for working life.

3 Objectives and Scope of the Product-based Thesis

3.1 Objectives and Research Questions

The thesis has two objectives:

1. Build a working first version of a movie discovery app for Android and iOS with React Native.
2. Evaluate how suitable React Native is for a beginner developer.

Main question: How suitable is React Native for a beginner developer to build a usable app for Android and iOS?

Supporting questions:

- **RQ1:** What was easy and what was difficult for me as a beginner when building the app with React Native?
- **RQ2:** Does the app work in the same way on Android and iOS, and how much extra work did each platform need?
- **RQ3:** How easy do young adults find the app to use?

3.2 Scope

To keep the project manageable, the scope is limited:

- **Included:** an app for Android and iOS that shows movie information, where a movie can be watched, suggestions based on filters and watchlist.
- **Not included:** a web or desktop version, user accounts and login, a backend server, publishing in app stores, and detailed performance measurements.
- **No own recommendation algorithm.** The suggestions come from ready-made features of the TMDB API.
- **Small study.** The results describe one beginner’s experience and a small user test. They are not statistical results.

3.3 Expected Results and Indicators of Success

The thesis is successful when:

- The main features work on both Android and iOS.
- The tests and user tests are done as planned.
- The results are analyzed and the research questions are answered.

The SUS average of 68 is only used as a reference point (Lewis 2018). A low usability score or technical problems are not failures. They are also useful results when I analyze and discuss them.

4 The Theoretical Framework of the Thesis

Academic and research-based sources are used for the main concepts, and official documentation only for technical details.

4.1 Cross-Platform Mobile Development

- Approaches to mobile development (native, web-based hybrid and cross-platform frameworks) and criteria for evaluating them, such as development effort, look and feel, and platform support (Heitkötter, Hanschke & Majchrzak 2013; Biørn-Hansen et al. 2018).
- React Native fundamentals: component model, Expo and the New Architecture (Meta Platforms 2026).
- Earlier comparisons of React Native and Flutter (Fentaw 2020).

4.2 Mobile Usability and User Experience

- Definition of usability as effectiveness, efficiency and satisfaction in a specified context of use (ISO 9241-11:2018).
- Special features of mobile usability, such as small screens, touch input and changing context of use (Zhang & Adipat 2005; Harrison, Flood & Duce 2013).
- Usability heuristics for interface design (Nielsen 24 April 1994).
- Choice overload and how filtering can make choosing easier (Iyengar & Lepper 2000).

4.3 Usability Evaluation and the System Usability Scale

- Task-based usability testing, the think-aloud method (Rubin & Chisnell 2008) and severity rating of problems (Nielsen 1 November 1994).
- Sample size in qualitative usability testing (Nielsen 18 March 2000).
- The System Usability Scale: development, scoring, reliability and interpretation (Brooke 1996; Bangor, Kortum & Miller 2008; Lewis 2018).

4.4 Technical Background: External APIs

- Using a REST API in a mobile application, including loading and error states and caching responses (TanStack 2026).
- The TMDB API and its streaming availability data (The Movie Database 2026).

5 Description of the Product-based Thesis

5.1 Target Users

The target users are young adults aged 18–30 in Finland who use at least two streaming services. They watch a lot of streaming content and use mobile apps every day. I find survey respondents and test users among students and through my own network.

5.2 Similar Apps

Some apps already solve part of the problem:

- **JustWatch**: Shows where a movie is available.
- **Letterboxd**: Only paid subscription can use the streaming availability services.

My app focuses on helping to decide, it shows suggestions only from the services the user has, in their own country, in a simple interface. The goal is not to compete with these apps. The app is the tool for evaluating React Native.

The app uses ready-made features of the TMDB API:

- **Similar movies:** TMDB's "similar" and "recommendations" lists for a selected movie. TMDB calculates these lists.
- **Filters:** the user chooses genres and their streaming services, and the app asks TMDB for matching movies.
- **Trending movies:** TMDB's trending and popular lists.

My own work is the app's design, the screens and combining and filtering this data. The quality of TMDB's suggestions is not evaluated.

5.3 Data Sources: TMDB and JustWatch

I have checked the role of the data sources from the TMDB documentation:

- **TMDB API** gives all movie information: titles, posters, genres, ratings, similar movies and streaming availability. The app must show that the data comes from TMDB.
- **JustWatch** is not used directly. TMDB gets its streaming availability data from JustWatch, so the app must show “Data provided by JustWatch” on the movie page.
- **Finland:** availability is given per country, so Finnish data comes from the same request. The data shows which services have a movie, but it does not give direct links to the services.
- **Limitation:** the data can be incomplete or out of date. I check which services TMDB lists for Finland and mention any gaps in the thesis.

5.4 Development Process

I use an agile way of working with one-week sprints. Features are written as user stories and the most important ones are done first. I test the app on Android and iPhone after every sprint.

Already done (March–October 2026): I learned React Native and Expo, made Figma wireframes (Appendix 1), and built the app setup and navigation, TMDB connection, trending home page, search, movie detail page, where-to-watch information and watchlist.

The remaining tasks are filtering by genre and streaming services, changing the country, similar movies and error messages.

Requirements: a short anonymous survey (Webropol) for young adults aged 18–30 checks that the problem is real and which features are most important. The goal is 20–30 answers.

5.5 Testing and Evaluation

5.5.1 Functional tests

I test each main feature with the test cases in Table 1. I run them on both phones and write the results (works / does not work, notes) in a test log. I might also write a few automatic unit tests with Jest for the filtering code.

Table 1. Functional test cases

ID	Features	Test	Expected Result
F1	Search	Search for a known movie	The movie is on the list

ID	Features	Test	Expected Result
F2	Where to watch	Open movie, country Finland	Services in Finland are shown
F3	Change Country	Change the country to Sweden	Services for Sweden are shown
F4	Filters	Choose a genre and two services	Only matching movies are shown
F5	Similar movies	Open similar movies	A list of similar movies is shown
F6	Watchlist	Add a movie, close and open the app	The movie is still on the watch-list
F7	No results	Use filters with no matches	A “no results” message is shown

5.5.2 Cross-Platform Tests

I run all test cases F1–F7 with the same app version on my Android phone and an iPhone. I also check one small and one large screen with emulators. For each test I write down:

- if it works on both platforms
- differences in layout, text or navigation (with screenshots)
- code I had to write separately for Android or iOS.

5.5.3 Usability tests and SUS

I test the app with 5–8 users aged 18–30, some on Android and some on iPhone. The tests are done in two rounds: about 5 users first, then I fix the biggest problems, and then 3 more users test again. One test takes about 30 minutes and follows the script in Appendix 3:

1. Short introduction and consent form (Appendices 4 and 5)
2. Five tasks while thinking aloud (Table 2)
3. SUS questionnaire
4. Short interview: What was easy? What was confusing? What was missing?

Table 2. Test tasks

Tasks	Tasks given to the user	Task is done when
T1	A friend recommended a movie, find where you can stream it in Finland	The user names the right service
T2	You only have Netflix and Disney+, find a comedy movie.	The user opens matching movie
T3	You liked a movie you saw recently, find similar movies.	The similar movies list is open
T4	Save two movies to watch later and find them again.	Both movies are on the watchlist
T5	Check if a certain movie is available in Sweden	The country changed, movie title is searched.

What I measure in each task: if the user finished the task (alone, with help, or not at all), how long it took, mistakes, and problems I saw. I rate each problem on a scale from 0 to 4, from “not a usability problem” to “usability catastrophe” (Nielsen 1 November 1994).

SUS: right after the tasks, the user answers the 10 SUS questions on a scale from 1 to 5 (Appendix 3). They answer alone, without my help. I calculate the SUS score in the standard way: for questions 1, 3, 5, 7 and 9 the score is the answer minus 1; for questions 2, 4, 6, 8 and 10 it is 5 minus the answer. The total is multiplied by 2.5, which gives a score from 0 to 100 (Brooke 1996).

I report each user’s score, the average, and the lowest and highest score, for all users and separately for Android and iPhone. I compare the results with the SUS average of 68 and the adjective scale of Bangor, Kortum and Miller (2009). Because the group is small, the results are only indicative.

5.5.4 Development Diary

During the whole project, I will write a short diary entry for each feature or problem: time used, what the problem was, how I solved it, and what helped (documentation, videos, forums). At the end, I group the notes into themes: learning, amount of work, tools and documentation, and extra

work for each platform. I compare these with the criteria in the literature (Heitkötter et al. 2013). This answers RQ1.

5.6 Tools

- React Native, Expo and Expo Router
- TypeScript and NativeWind
- Axios and TanStack Query for loading data
- TMDB API (streaming availability data from JustWatch)
- AsyncStorage for saving the watchlist on the phone
- Figma for design, Git and GitHub for version control
- Jest for unit tests, Expo Go on an Android phone and an iPhone
- Webropol for the survey and the SUS questionnaire

No costs are expected. All tools are free or provided by Haaga-Helia.

6 Data Management Plan

- **App data:** the app uses public movie data from TMDB. The watchlist is saved only on the user's own phone.
- **Survey:** the survey is anonymous. It does not ask for names or email addresses, and age is asked only as an age group. The first question asks for consent.
- **User tests:** before the test, users get the Participant Information Sheet (Appendix 4) and sign the consent form. The signed forms contain names, so they are personal data. In my notes and results, users are called P1, P2 and so on. I do not record video or audio.
- **Controller:** the thesis has no client, so Haaga-Helia and I are joint controllers of the personal data.
- **Storage:** all data is stored in Haaga-Helia's OneDrive/Teams, not on USB sticks or personal drives. Paper consent forms are scanned to OneDrive, and the paper copies are destroyed (Haaga-Helia Library and Information Services 2026).
- **Deletion:** after the thesis is approved, the consent forms, test notes and survey answers are deleted, at the latest on 31.1.2027.
- **AI tools:** I used Claude (Anthropic), an AI assistant, to help edit the document to Haaga Helia specification, simplify the language. I checked all sources myself. AI text is not used as a source.

7 Structure of the Thesis Report

The report follows the traditional structure (template Appendix 1):

1. Introduction: background, problem, questions and scope
2. Theory: cross-platform development, mobile usability, usability testing and SUS
3. Planning and design: survey results, similar apps, user stories, wireframes
4. Building the app: sprints, main technical solutions and problems
5. Testing and results: functional and cross-platform tests, user tests and SUS, development diary
6. Discussion: answers to the questions, reliability, ethics, limitations, my own learning, ideas for the future
7. References and appendices: GitHub link, survey, test materials, wireframes, screenshots of the app

The app is shown with screenshots and a link to the source code on GitHub.

8 Problem Areas and Risks

The problems and their mitigation are shown in Table 3.

Table 3. Problems and mitigation

Risks	Likelihood	Impact	What I do
Tight Schedule	High	High	Main features are already done; I write theory while building. I follow weekly plan.
Too many new features	Medium	Medium	I only build the planned features.
Missing streaming data	Medium	Medium	I checked data in week 43 and use test movies that have data
Apps work differently on Android and iOS	Medium	Medium	I test on both phones every week.
Not enough test users	Medium	High	I ask people early from several places, tests are short.
TMDB API is down or limits requests	Low	High	The app saves loaded data; I keep test data on my PC.

Reliability: I use the same tasks and tests cases for all users and both platforms; I write results down right away and report problems honestly.

9 Schedule

The main features have been built since March 2026. The thesis will be completed by 30.11.2026. The detailed schedule is shown in Table 4.

Table 4. Schedule

Week	Tasks
March-October 2026	Learning React Native; wireframes, setup, TMDB, home page, search, movie page, where to watch, watchlist
Week 43	Send survey, check TMDB data for Finland, start theory chapters
Week 44	Build filters, country change, similar movies and error messages, functional and cross-platform tests, write theory
Week 45	User tests round 1 (about 5 users); write planning and building chapters.
Week 46	Fix the biggest problems; user tests round 2 (3 users); analyze diary
Week 47	Write results and discussion; send draft to supervisor
Week 48	Final changes; plagiarism check; maturity test; publish on Theseus

10 Thesis Grade

My target grade is 5. To reach it, I will:

- use academic sources in the theory and connect them to my results
- build a working app with clean code
- answer the research questions with real evidence from tests, users and my diary
- discuss the results, their limitations and my own learning honestly.

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Appendices

Appendix 1. First wireframe design of the app

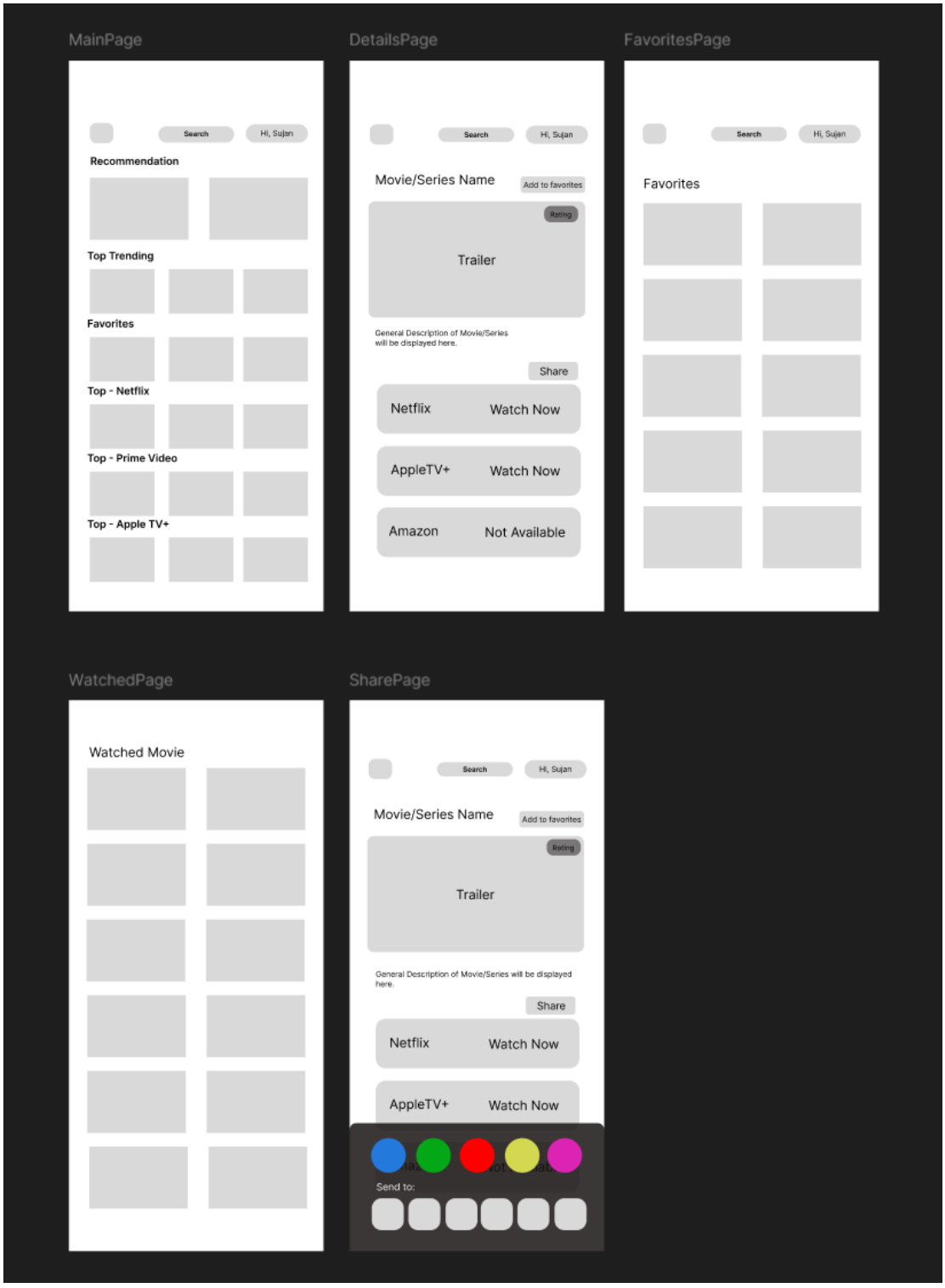


Figure 1. First wireframe design of the app (Figma)

Appendix 2. Survey questions

Anonymous Webropol survey for young adults aged 18–30. Time: about 3–5 minutes. The first question is the consent question (Appendix 5, Option 1).

1. What is your age group? (18–21 / 22–25 / 26–30)
2. Which streaming services do you use? (Netflix, Disney+, HBO Max, Prime Video, Yle Areena, Ruutu, Viaplay, other)
3. How often do you watch movies or series on streaming services? (daily / a few times a week / weekly / less often)
4. How do you usually decide what to watch? (the service's suggestions, friends, social media, review sites, other)
5. How often do you search for where a movie or series is available? (often / sometimes / rarely / never)
6. Which apps or websites do you use to find where to watch something? (JustWatch, Letterboxd, Google, other, none)
7. How difficult is it to decide what to watch? (1 = very easy … 5 = very difficult)
8. What is the most annoying thing when you look for something to watch? (open answer)
9. Which features are most important to you? Put them in order: where to watch; suggestions; watchlist; filter by my services; ratings.

Appendix 3. User test script and SUS questionnaire

Test script (about 30 minutes)

1. Welcome (3 min): explain that we test the app, not the user, and that the user can stop at any time. Go through the Participant Information Sheet and sign the consent form.
2. Background (2 min): age group, streaming services used, phone used every day.
3. Thinking aloud (1 min): ask the user to say aloud what they think while using the app.
4. Tasks T1–T5 (15 min): read each task from Table 2 and give it on paper. I do not help, unless the user is stuck for more than 3 minutes (marked as “done with help”).
5. SUS questionnaire (3 min): the user answers alone.
6. Interview (5 min): What was easy? What was confusing? What was missing?
7. Thank you and end (1 min).

System Usability Scale (Brooke 1996)

Answer each statement: 1 = strongly disagree, 2 = disagree, 3 = neutral, 4 = agree, 5 = strongly agree.

1. I think that I would like to use this app frequently.
2. I found the app unnecessarily complex.
3. I thought the app was easy to use.
4. I think that I would need the support of a technical person to be able to use this app.
5. I found the various functions in this app were well integrated.
6. I thought there was too much inconsistency in this app.
7. I imagine that most people would learn to use this app very quickly.
8. I found the app very cumbersome to use.
9. I felt very confident using the app.
10. I needed to learn a lot of things before I could get going with this app.

Appendix 4. Participant Information Sheet

The participant information sheet will be distributed to the participants of the study as a printed or electronic document along with the consent form (Appendix 5).

Participant Information Sheet

Title of the Thesis: Building a Cross-Platform Movie Discovery App with React Native: A Beginner Developer's Evaluation and Usability Study

Student's Name and Contact Information: Sujan Tiwari, Haaga-Helia University of Applied Sciences, bhu091@myy.haaga-helia.fi

Commissioning Party: None. This is an independent thesis at Haaga-Helia University of Applied Sciences.

Objective of Data Collection: To find out what young adults need when choosing what to watch (survey) and how easy the movie discovery app is to use (user test).

Method and Phases of Data Collection: Survey: an anonymous online survey in Webropol. User test: a face-to-face session where the participant uses the app on a phone, completes five tasks while thinking aloud, fills in a short questionnaire (SUS) and answers three interview questions. The researcher takes written notes. No video or audio is recorded.

Duration of Participation: Survey: about 3–5 minutes. User test: about 30 minutes.

Pre-preparation: No preparation is needed.

Benefits of Participation for the Participant or their Represented Organization: Participants help to make the app easier to use and can try a new movie discovery app. There is no payment.

Processing, storage, access and disposal of the data: The data is processed and analyzed using the storage services and software provided by Haaga-Helia. Only the student has access to it. The survey does not collect personal data. In the user test, the only personal data is the participant's name and signature on the consent form; in the notes and results, participants are called P1, P2 and so on. The legal basis for processing personal data is the consent of the data subject. The processing of personal data and the rights of the data subject comply with the EU General Data Protection Regulation (General Data Protection Regulation 2016/679/EU) and the applicable national legislation. The data will be destroyed no later than 31.1.2027.

Controller: The thesis is not commissioned, so Sujan Tiwari and Haaga-Helia University of Applied Sciences are joint controllers. The student is responsible for collecting, storing and deleting the data. Haaga-Helia provides the secure storage services. Contact details of Haaga-Helia's Data Protection Officer at ilkka.valve@haaga-helia.fi.

Publication of Results: The thesis report will be published in the Theseus online library. No participant can be identified from the results.

Funding and Potential Conflicts of Interest: None

Additional Information: Sujan Tiwari, Haaga-Helia University of Applied Sciences, bhu091@myy.haaga-helia.fi

Voluntary participation and withdrawal of consent: Participation is voluntary. Survey: consent cannot be withdrawn after pressing the submit button, because individual answers cannot be identified. User test: consent can be withdrawn at any time without giving a reason, for example by stopping the test. Once the results have been analyzed, it is not possible to remove one participant's answers afterwards.

Appendix 5. Participant Consent

Option 1: Survey (first question in the Webropol survey)

1. I have read the Participant Information Sheet and give my consent to participate in the study in accordance with the research announcement.

○ Yes

○ No. To complete this form, you must give your consent.

Option 2: User test (paper form)

Participant's Consent

Name of the study: Building a Cross-Platform Movie Discovery App with React Native: A Beginner Developer's Evaluation and Usability Study

The author of the study: Sujan Tiwari, Haaga-Helia University of Applied Sciences, bhu091@myy.haaga-helia.fi

I have read the Participant Information Sheet. With my signature, I confirm that I give my consent to participate in the research.

_____

Name of the consent giver

_____ _____

Signature Date